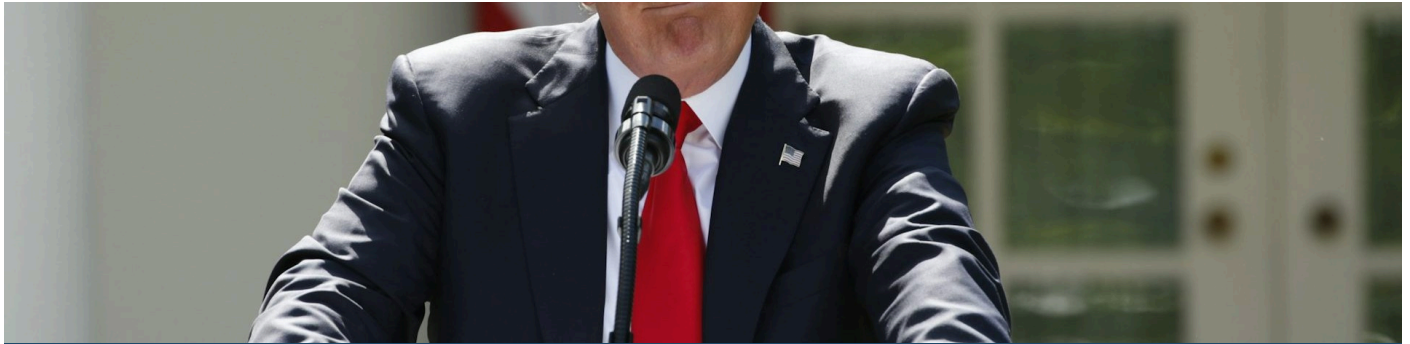




Global Climate Policy and International Cooperation: Analyzing the Paris Accord

Abstract

On June 1, 2017, President Donald Trump announced that the United States would withdraw from the Paris climate agreement. The Conversation assembled a panel of experts to analyze the decision. This lesson uses their perspectives, from a climate scientist, a business scholar, an Earth scientist, and an agriculture specialist, to explore how international climate agreements work and who is affected when a major country leaves.

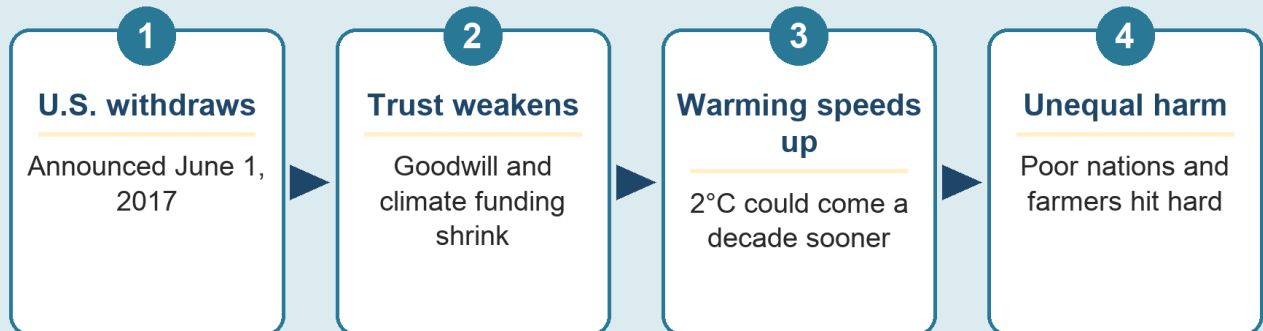
Introduction

The Paris Agreement is a landmark global deal to lower greenhouse gas emissions and limit the harm from climate change. Nearly every country joined. When the U.S. announced its withdrawal, only Syria and Nicaragua had also stayed outside the accord. The decision raised big questions. How can an agreement work if its largest historical emitter walks away? What happens to promised funding for poor countries? Does leaving help or hurt American businesses and farmers? Experts from several fields weighed in, showing that climate policy is not only about science, but also about economics, fairness, trust, and international relationships.

How Do Scientists Study This?

This lesson analyzes a policy decision from multiple expert perspectives, a method used in policy analysis to understand complex issues. Climate scientist Kevin Trenberth examined the scientific and diplomatic consequences, including the timing of dangerous warming. Business professor Marina Whitman analyzed economic and trade impacts. Earth scientist Anthony Janetos focused on the world's poor and climate finance. Agriculture specialist Matthew Russell considered effects on American farmers. By comparing their arguments and evidence, readers can see how a single decision creates ripple effects across science, the economy, and society, and weigh competing claims about costs and benefits.

Ripple effects of leaving Paris



Identify the decision

The U.S. announced it would leave the Paris climate accord on June 1, 2017.

Gather perspectives

Experts in climate science, business, global development, and farming analyzed impacts.

Weigh consequences

Compare effects on the climate, the economy, poor nations, and trust between countries.

What Did They Discover?

Trenberth explained that the Paris Agreement is based on goodwill, with no penalties. The U.S. had pledged \$3 billion to the Green Climate Fund, which helps developing countries adapt, but delivered only \$1 billion. Without the U.S. and Paris, he warned, the world could cross the dangerous 2°C threshold before 2060, perhaps a decade earlier, while full implementation might delay it by 40 years. Whitman noted that companies like General Electric and 3M, and even oil companies, urged staying in, and 30 CEOs warned of trade consequences. Janetos stressed that climate impacts fall hardest on poor people and countries. Russell argued the decision ignored American farmers as a key asset in reducing emissions.

The Paris decision by the numbers

\$1B

delivered of \$3 billion pledged to the Green Climate Fund

195

signatory countries to the Paris accord

40 yrs

possible delay of 2°C if Paris is fully implemented

Trenberth argued the U.S. has a moral responsibility to lead, as the country that has contributed more than any other to accumulated emissions.

FROM THE ARTICLE



Industrial powerhouses like General Electric and 3M urged the president to stay in the plan. Photo: Richard Schneider/flickr, CC BY-NC.



Leaving the Paris Agreement negatively affects farmers in other countries. Photo: CIFOR/flickr, CC BY-NC-ND.

Takeaways

Goodwill is the glue

Paris has no enforcement, so trust and leadership keep it working.

Timing matters

Delaying 2°C of warming by decades gives societies more time to adapt.

Impacts are unequal

Poor countries that did least to cause warming are hit hardest.

Key Terms

Paris Agreement

A 2015 international agreement in which countries pledged to cut greenhouse gas emissions and limit global warming.

Green Climate Fund

A United Nations fund that helps developing countries reduce emissions and adapt to climate change.

2°C threshold

A level of global warming above pre-industrial temperatures beyond which scientists expect the most dangerous impacts.

Carbon tax

A fee on fossil fuels based on their carbon emissions, meant to reflect their true costs.

Accumulated emissions

The total greenhouse gases a country has released over time, which determines its share of warming.

Activity

Expert Panel Debate

Students role-play the expert panel and debate the effects of leaving an international climate agreement.

Materials: Role cards: climate scientist, business leader, development expert, farmer, government official; Evidence organizer; Timer

1. Each student takes a role card and reads the related section of the lesson.
2. Prepare a two-minute statement using at least two pieces of evidence.
3. Hold the panel: each role speaks, then the audience asks questions.
4. As a class, map how one decision affected science, business, poor countries, and farmers.
5. Write a short policy memo recommending what a country should do and why.

References

Trenberth, K., Whitman, M. v. N., Janetos, A., Russell, M., et al. (2017). Why Trump's decision to leave Paris accord hurts the US and the world. *The Conversation*. <https://doi.org/10.64628/AAI.ujeax46mw>